Customer Interview Guide

Plan, run and write up conversations that reveal real behavior. Ask about the past, not the future, and about their life, not your idea.

1. Learning goals

What are the three things you most need to learn from these interviews?

What do you currently believe about each one? Write it down so you can check it later.

Who exactly do you need to talk to, and where will you find them?

2. Opening questions

Tell me about the last time you [experienced the problem]. What happened?

What is the hardest part about [the job they are trying to get done]?

How do you handle this today?

3. Going deeper

What happened next? Why was that hard?

What have you tried to fix it? What did that cost you?

If you could change one thing about how this works, what would it be?

Who else should I talk to about this?

4. Write-up (within 24 hours)

Three direct quotes that stood out.

Workarounds, costs and current tools they mentioned.

What surprised you or contradicted your assumptions?

Signals of real interest: did they ask to try something, offer an introduction or describe paying for a fix?

5. Across all five interviews

Which themes came up three or more times?

Which of your assumptions changed the most?

What is the one question you will investigate next?